

The APEASE Criteria

A framework for making decisions in intervention design

The APEASE criteria provide a structured framework for making decisions throughout the process of developing and evaluating behaviour -change interventions. They can be applied when identifying the most appropriate people to try to influence, the behaviours to target, the capability, opportunity and motivation factors to try to address, the choice of broad intervention functions and behaviour change techniques, and decisions about how best to deliver those techniques. They can also be applied to the evaluations made of interventions and their components.

Affordability	Whether the option is likely to result in an intervention can be delivered to, or accessed by, enough people for whom it is relevant within the budget realistically available. An option that works but cannot be funded at the required scale fails this test. Ask: <i>Can we afford to deliver this to the whole target population, not just a pilot?</i>
Practicability	Whether the option is likely to result in an intervention that can be delivered as designed, through the means intended, to the target population, in the context for which it is intended — not just under ideal or controlled conditions. Ask: <i>Do we have the staff, skills, infrastructure and reach to deliver this as designed?</i>
Effectiveness & cost-effectiveness	Effectiveness is the size of the effect on the target behaviour in a real-world setting (distinct from efficacy under optimal conditions). Cost-effectiveness is that effect relative to cost. A highly effective option may still be rejected if its cost-effectiveness is poor against alternatives. Ask: <i>How large is the likely real-world effect, and is it good value compared with other options?</i>
Acceptability	Whether the option is judged appropriate by relevant stakeholders. Acceptability frequently differs across groups — the public, the target group, practitioners, commissioners and policymakers — and what is acceptable in principle may not be in a particular form. Ask: <i>Who needs to find this acceptable, and would each of them endorse it in this form?</i>
Spill-over effects	Whether the option could result in desired or unwanted spill-over effects. An option may be effective and practicable yet still cause harm that outweighs its benefits, or conversely it might create some bonus effects beyond the immediate target. Ask: <i>What could go wrong, and are the risks and unintended consequences acceptable, or are there any potential bonus effects?</i>
Equity	The extent to which the option widens or narrows disparities in wellbeing, health or standard of living between sectors of society. Interventions can easily increase inequalities, so this must be considered explicitly. Ask: <i>Will this reduce or widen existing inequalities across the population?</i>

Using APEASE in practice

Apply the criteria as a transparent appraisal step, not a one-off gate. List the candidate options, rate each against all six criteria (a simple high/medium/low or 0–2 scoring is often enough), and record the reasoning. The aim is not a single composite score but a structured, defensible judgement: making the trade-offs visible — for example, a more effective option that is less affordable or less equitable — is the real value of the exercise. Revisit the appraisal as evidence accumulates and as the delivery context changes.

Last updated: 17th June 2026 by Robert West